ATHLETICS (5E, 2024 RULES) – DESCRIPTION

Athletics is a **Strength** skill. It is used to **jump farther than normal**, to **keep your head above water** in violent flows, or to **break something**. The DM decides when a roll is needed: when the outcome is **uncertain** and **interesting**.

🎲 Quick summary:

1. An Athletics check is an **ability check**: d20 + Strength modifier (+ Proficiency Bonus if proficient).
2. The **DM sets the DC** using the official scale: 5, 10, 15, 20, 25, 30.
3. On an ability check, a **20** or a **1** has no special effect: no critical here.
4. The DM may call for **another ability** if the situation fits (see the **Use cases** page).
5. **Advantage** and **Disadvantage** apply normally (for example through an ally's **Help** action).

⚠ Using another ability:

- The ability of a check is **decided by the situation**. The DM may ask, for example, for **Constitution (Athletics)** for an endurance effort (marathon, open-sea swim). Table rule
- The **Proficiency Bonus** applies when the skill **fits** and you are proficient.
- The rules cite **Strength (Acrobatics or Athletics)** checks: one skill can pair with several abilities.

⚠ Change from 2014

The Athletics examples are **shorter**, with an **official DC scale**. Several DC 15s appear (slippery surface, rough water, falling into water). Escaping a grapple uses a **fixed DC**, and Athletics is no longer used to grapple.

⚠ Flaw in the rule and fixes

Few tasks have an official DC, and the line with **Acrobatics** is debated. Fix: the **DM announces** the ability, the skill, and the DC **before** the roll.

💡 Narrative option: Table rule

Describe the **effort**: burning muscles, scraped palms, short breath, the torrent's spray.

ATHLETICS (5E, 2024 RULES) – HOW TO PLAY

Step 1 – Decide whether a roll is needed:

A roll happens only if the outcome is **uncertain** and **interesting**. Otherwise, success is automatic or failure obvious.

Step 2 – Choose the ability and the skill:

By default: **Strength** (**Athletics**). The DM may pair **another ability** if the situation demands it, and says whether proficiency applies.

Step 3 – Set the DC:

The task is...	DC
Very easy	5
Easy	10
Moderate	15
Hard	20
Very hard	25
Nearly impossible	30

Step 4 – Make the roll:

d20 + Strength modifier + **Proficiency Bonus** if you are proficient in Athletics. An ally can use the **Help** action to give you **Advantage**.

Example: Brann (Strength +3, Proficiency +2) crosses a rough torrent (DC 15). He rolls 11 + 3 + 2 = 16: success.

Step 5 – Resolve:

- **Total ≥ DC**: the attempt succeeds.
- **Total < DC**: it fails. The DM describes the consequence (a slip, a fall, lost time). Table rule
- A 20 or a 1 on the d20 **changes nothing** on an ability check.

ATHLETICS (5E, 2024 RULES) – TABLES

Athletics uses in the 2024 rules:

Situation	Check and DC
Climb a slippery surface or one with few handholds	Strength (Athletics) **DC 15** (DM's call)
Move through rough water	Strength (Athletics) **DC 15** (DM's call)
Jump over a low obstacle (hedge, low wall)	Strength (Athletics) **DC 10** (obstacle ≤ ¼ of the jump's length). Failure: you hit it
Fall into water (Reaction)	Strength (Athletics) or Dexterity (Acrobatics) **DC 15**: fall damage halved
Escape a grapple (action)	Strength (Athletics) or Dexterity (Acrobatics) against **the grapple's DC**
Land in Difficult Terrain after a jump	Dexterity (Acrobatics) **DC 10**, otherwise Prone

Formulas to know:

What	Formula (Strength 16, modifier +3)
Long Jump, with a 10-foot run	Strength score in feet = **16 feet** (standing: 8 feet)
High Jump, with a 10-foot run	3 feet + Strength modifier = **6 feet** (standing: half)
Carrying capacity	Strength × 15 lb = **240 lb**
Lift, push, drag	Strength × 30 lb = **480 lb**

*Jumps and loads need no roll: Athletics comes into play to go **beyond normal** (a longer jump, an extreme effort).*

Table DC suggestions (unofficial): Table rule

Action	Suggested DC
Force open a stuck door	10 to 15
Break a barred door	20
Lift a portcullis	20 to 25
Pull yourself up onto a ledge	10

ATHLETICS (5E, 2024 RULES) – USE CASES

Ability + skill combinations: Table rule

*The DM decides the ability by the situation and applies skill proficiency if it fits. These combinations are **exceptions announced before the roll**.*

Combination	Use in play
Strength (Intimidation)	Break an object, bend bars, or carry a massive table to threaten.
Strength (Persuasion)	Win the respect of warriors or brutes with a physical display (arm wrestling).
Dexterity (Investigation)	Carefully search an area full of sensitive traps without setting any off.
Constitution (Athletics)	Sustain intense physical effort over the very long term (marathon, open-sea swim).
Constitution (Stealth)	Stay motionless in a painful position for hours without moving an eyelash.
Intelligence (Persuasion)	Convince a court or a king with an unbeatable logical argument.
Intelligence (Sleight of Hand)	Manipulate a geometric puzzle or disarm a logic trap.
Charisma (Stealth)	Practice "social stealth" (pass as a waiter to infiltrate a party).

Other combinations consistent with Athletics: Table rule

Combination	Use in play
Dexterity (Athletics)	Sprint, obstacle course, or technical hurdle: speed and coordination outweigh strength.
Intelligence (Athletics)	Read a wall or a current to choose the right climbing or swimming technique.
Wisdom (Athletics)	Manage breath and pace to save strength in a long trial.
Charisma (Athletics)	A public contest of strength or throwing to impress the crowd.
Strength (Acrobatics)	Hold a balance or pull up by strength rather than agility.

How to choose: Table rule

1. What does the task demand: **power, agility, endurance, mind, presence**? That gives the ability.
2. Which skill describes the **know-how**? Apply proficiency if it fits.
3. The DM **announces** the combination and the DC before the roll.

Example: Mira (Constitution +2, Athletics proficiency +2) swims 3 hours at sea, DC 15. She rolls 10 + 2 + 2 = 14: failure. Table suggestion: 1 Exhaustion level.

ATHLETICS (5E, 2024 RULES) – Q&A AND DEBATE

Common table questions.

Can you use Athletics with an ability other than Strength?

Yes: the ability is decided by the situation. The DM may ask for **Constitution (Athletics)** for an endurance swim or run, and applies proficiency if it fits. See the **Use cases** page. Table rule

Can I combine Athletics and Intimidation?

Yes, as a table rule: **Strength (Intimidation)** to break an object or bend bars in order to threaten. The task is physical, but the goal is to frighten. Table rule

Athletics or Acrobatics?

Athletics: power (jumping farther, swimming, breaking). **Acrobatics**: balance and acrobatic feats. To escape a grapple or when falling into water, the player chooses either.

Is a 20 on the d20 an automatic success?

No: on an ability check, a **20** or a **1** has no special effect. There is no critical.

Do I need a roll to climb or swim?

Not always: climbing or swimming simply costs **double** movement. A roll comes only in hard conditions (slippery surface, rough water).

Do grappling and shoving use Athletics?

Not since 2024: it is the target's **saving throw**. Athletics is only used to **escape** a grapple.

How much can I lift?

Strength × 30 lb to lift, push, or drag, and Strength × 15 lb carried. Beyond that, the DM may call for an Athletics check.

Can I jump a 20-foot chasm?

With Strength 16, the Long Jump is 16 feet: an Athletics check at a DC set by the DM may let you **exceed** normal, as the skill allows.

Which features help?

A Barbarian's **Rage** gives Advantage on Strength checks. **Expertise** doubles the Proficiency Bonus. The Rogue can treat a 9 or lower as a 10.

Can an ally help me?

Yes, with the **Help** action: Advantage on your next ability check with the chosen skill.

⚠ Rule clarifications (answers found on the web, reworded):

20 and 1 on a check

On an ability check, a 20 or a 1 has no special effect: no Critical Hit, no automatic failure.

Grappled and attacks

A Grappled creature can still attack: the condition only limits its movement.

Moving through a space

You can move through a Prone enemy's space only if it is Incapacitated, Tiny, or at least two sizes different from you.

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